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Inside the Multilingual Brain

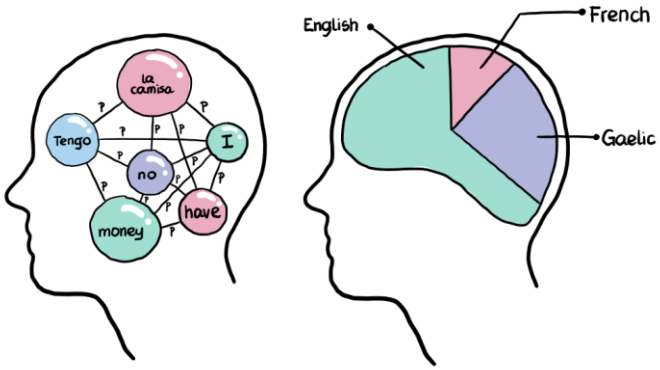
…a.k.a. why the term ‘first language’ makes no sense.

As a speaker of multiple languages, I have had many opportunities to discuss the interaction of language and thought with my surroundings. While doing that, I discovered that most people have no idea what it actually means, to be multilingual.

Let’s talk about what it’s like.

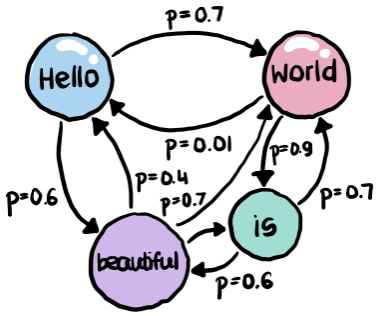
The Multilingual Lexicon

First, multilingualism doesn’t mean that one speaks, say, half language X and half language Y. Multilingual speech is not a pie chart that could be divided into slices based on how well one speaks any given language.



Language is a multidimensional set of expressions. These expressions, which could be visualised as nodes distributed in space, are interconnected by edges marking the probability that a speaker will naturally place any two expressions in adjacent positions.

These (not necessarily symmetric)* probabilities are assigned by intuition, current mood, and previous experience hearing and/or using any two expressions in adjacent positions. Whether or not they belong to the same language does not play a role.



Acquiring a new language does not mean one's brain creates a new, parallel set and switches between multiple independent lexical sets. The process of a new language acquisition adds nodes to an already existing set and creates thus a multilingual idiolect unique to the speaker.

This also entails that there is no 'default' language for polyglots to fall back to. It's not like after an all-day-long shift of speaking your 'second' or 'third' language, you need to take a break and switch back to your 'first' language.

All expressions, regardless of the language, are stored in the same inventory. Sometimes it takes cognitive energy to deny a more intuitive choice of word for the sake of being consistent in language, but no mechanical translation takes place.

If a speaker is truly multilingual—as opposed to having mechanically learnt an additional language without acquiring the emotion that comes with expressions in each language—switching between their 'first' and 'second' and 'third' and, in fact, their gazillionth language is effortless.

'Your first language, ma'am?'

Because of the inseparability of the multilingual lexicon, I've always felt uneasy when asked to specify my 'first' language. What's the phrase 'first language' even supposed to mean, especially when ripped out of context? I've entertained a couple of possibilities.

'First' language could be the language one learnt first—except it's not. The first language Ying, a boy I met in Scotland, picked up as a child was Japanese. He barely understands any Japanese these days; selecting it as his 'first' language for legal or working purposes would leave him vastly incapacitated.

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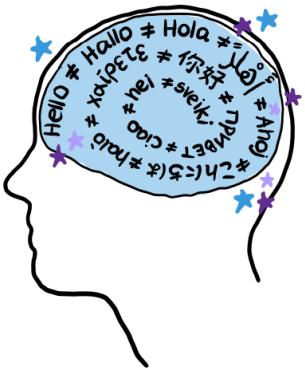
* *Symmetric probability* between any two lexical items would mean that the probability of item A following item B in a sentence is the same as the probability of B following A.

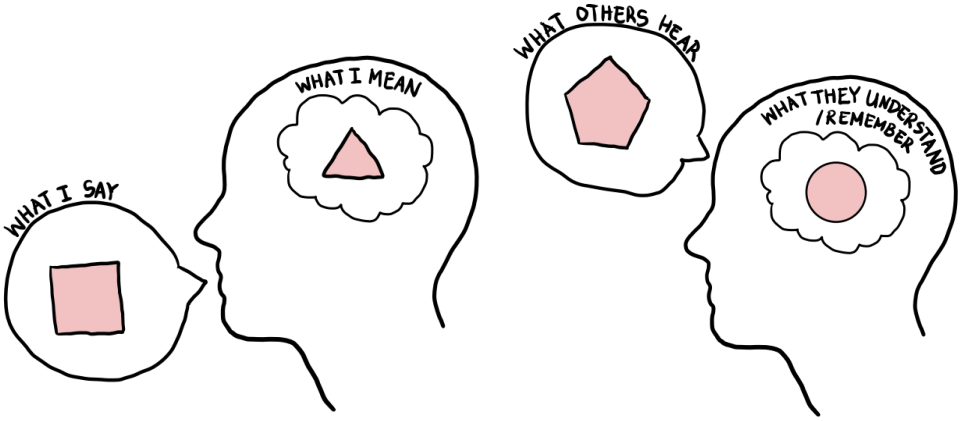
‘First’ language can’t be the language one sounds ‘native’ in, either. My accent has been termed ‘alien’ in all the languages I speak. George, my History of Writing TA, sounds ‘native’ in at least three languages he speaks. It’s impossible to pinpoint a singular ‘first’ language in these cases, too.

It’s also not the language one speaks the ‘best’. I don’t think there is a language a multilingual brain speaks the ‘best’ or the ‘worst’. (Though skills do indeed get rusty when out of use.) Language is a tool to express thoughts. In order to express thoughts accurately, every component of the speech produced must *feel* optimal enough.*


Hello ≠ Hallo ≠ Hola ≠ 你好 ≠ ¡Ahoj ≠ Hallo ≠ ciao ≠ ¡Hola

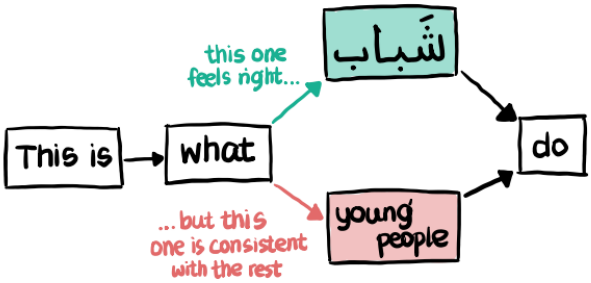
Translation is a separate skill of selecting the best approximation of what a speaker of a language X says in terms of the vocabulary and syntax of language Y. The outcome should sound *correct* but not necessarily *natural* to a language Y speaker's ear. *Good* translation sounds both correct *and* natural.

(This is why there are so few quality translations of artworks, for instance. The original text is already an approximation of its author's thoughts, and the translation is only magnifying the gap between what the author meant and what the text ends up saying.)



Multilingualism is neither a necessary nor a sufficient condition for mastering translation. One does not need to have a multilingual brain to be able to translate, just as those with multilingual minds need not necessarily be able to give translations any splendid. Many of them will, in fact, turn out quite underwhelming.

When limited to a single language, most multilingual minds will end up calquing a *lot*.* The speech they'll produce will consist of mechanically translated expressions or, worse yet, morphosyntactic compositions, and may even present too difficult to understand—unless they worked on their translation skill.



A lot of what's going on inside the multilingual mind is still beyond my (and possibly anyone else's) understanding. What I do know, though, is that for as much as speaking multiple

* *Calque* is a term for literal (word-for-word) translation of a phrase from one language to another; calques normally do convey the message but may sound awkward when used outside the original tongue.

languages sets you free in many ways, the misperceptions about multilingualism may make it a little annoying.

Mind, polyglots are not proactively trying to make every listener's experience worse by mixing up languages. They might not have lied about fluently speaking a foreign language just because they can't give exemplary translations on spot.

They lack expressions that *feel* right in a particular language, they take time to dig up good enough approximations, and they calque. Some of us take a while to learn any better, so cheers to all those who ever had to put up with it—as well as to the ones who quit asking people for their 'first' language :)